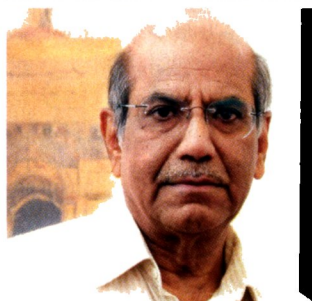




MANMOHAN (LEFT) WITH
RAMESH; DASGUPTA
(TOP); SARAN

Blow Hot, Blow Cold

■ **EMISSION TARGETS:** India announces it is willing to cut carbon emission intensity by 20-25 per cent. Detractors accuse Jairam Ramesh of not basing this on foolproof calculations.

■ **VERIFICATION:** The minister says India is ready to submit its mitigation actions for scrutiny. After protests, he clarifies that this would apply to foreign-funded initiatives.

■ **BINDING COMMITMENTS:** The minister draws the line and says India will not accept legally binding norms and will not agree to any peaking of its emission levels as has been proposed by the West.

industrial temperatures. With Manmohan acquiescing to the agreement there was domestic criticism that he was indirectly committing India to take on legally binding emission cuts. Manmohan though was clear that India had an important role to play and told his advisers, "We will have to work towards meeting the criterion. How long can we remain outside the international framework?"

As pressure built up on India to change its act, on a visit to China in September Ramesh was struck by the fact that the Chinese were holding a two-day special session of the National People's Congress to discuss emission control laws. He thought it would be a good idea if India considered fresh legislation. At the UN Special Summit on Climate Change in October, Ramesh surmised the negotiations were going nowhere with everybody reiterating their well-known positions. While developed countries were to commit themselves to legally binding emission cuts, developing countries like India had taken on Nationally Appropriate Mitigation Actions (NAMA).

Ramesh thought that NAMA in its current form was a lot of fluff. He felt India's per capita approach had run its course. The country needed a bolder, proactive approach if India was to have a major say at the Copenhagen summit. It struck him that with India having an ambitious plan on climate change, including a mission to generate 20,000 MW of power through solar plants, there was no need to shy away from putting it on the table. So, he proposed that developing countries be willing to take on voluntary energy

efficiency measures that would enable them to reduce their carbon emission intensity. These countries would be accountable to their own parliaments and coined the term Nationally Appropriate Mitigation Outcomes (NAMO).

When Jairam returned to Delhi he penned a letter to the prime minister, outlining a 10-point agenda that would give India enough "flexibility" for Indian negotiators calling it the "per-capita plus" approach. It included a proposal to have domestic legislation on climate management and NAMO. Ramesh ended the letter by saying, "India must be seen as pragmatic and constructive, not argumentative and polemical." But what angered India's climate hardliners was Ramesh's willingness to consider an Australian proposal that sought to blur the distinction between the developed (so-called Annex 1 countries under the Kyoto Protocol) and developing countries. Shyam Saran, India's chief negotiator on climate change, and Chandrasekhar Dasgupta, a former ambassador, also in the negotiating team, had viewed the Australian proposal as an attempt to scuttle the Kyoto Protocol and put an end to the historical responsibilities of developed countries towards emissions.

When Ramesh's letter was leaked opposition parties like the BJP charged him with compromising India's interests. Dasgupta threatened to pull out if this was India's new position. The Prime Minister's Office hastened to clarify